



Angkor Wat temples

Khmer troops pass through Cambodia's Angkor Wat temples. Pol Pot saw Angkor Wat as proof of what the Khmer people could accomplish. Bullet holes from battles between the Vietnamese and the Khmer Rouge can still be seen around the temples today.

Sino-Vietnamese conflict

Despite China's support during the Vietnam War, Sino-Vietnamese relations also had a long history of hostility. Vietnam and the People's Republic of China had border disputes and mutual claims to the Paracel and Spratly Islands. Vietnam's treatment of the 1.5 million ethnic Chinese who lived in Vietnam (known as the Hoa) also angered China. After 1975, more than 170,000 Hoa fled Vietnam and many became "boat people." The final straw for China was Vietnam's 1979 takeover of Kampuchea, an ally of China.

That February, China launched a punitive invasion with 200,000 forces penetrating about 25 miles (40 km) into Vietnam before they got bogged down and withdrew. It is estimated that China suffered at least 7,000–8,000 deaths in the three-week war. Vietnam never released military casualties but announced that 10,000 of its civilians died in the invasion. Border engagements continued through the 1980s until a settlement was reached in the late 1990s.

“Beijing has said **time and again** that they will teach us a **second lesson.**”

PHAM VAN DONG, PRIME MINISTER OF VIETNAM, 1979